

Neighbours **SRI LANKA**

while had converted his force into a near conventional army. He himself was pushing 50, resulting in a middle-aged sluggishness that affected the LTTE's flexibility. Desertions from his top rung of leaders, especially that of Karuna, saw his authority being challenged and his cadre split.

When the army took control of the Eastern Province in April 2007, Prabhakaran wasn't too perturbed. He believed that once the army started marching North where the majority of the LTTE's cadres were holed up, it would be so stretched that the LTTE could easily inflict telling blows and get it to retreat. Fonseka raised two additional divisions in a short span of time and began to push the LTTE into a corner. That was when Prabhakaran resorted to using Tamil civilians as a human shield to slow the army's progress. It worked for a while as the resultant collateral damage saw international opinion turn against the Sri Lankan Army and the US and Europe came down strongly on the deteriorating human rights situation. In the final month, Prabhakaran and his top cadres were pushed to a narrow strip of mangrove forests. The chance to slip

out of the cordon had receded and the LTTE finally collapsed in a rush.

Fonseka puts the number of LTTE cadre killed at 22,000. The Army's own loss is over 5,000 and some 15,000 injured. There are no authentic accounts of how many civilians died but they run into thousands. Worse, a terrible human tragedy is unfolding with around three lakh Tamils huddled into temporary tents and unable to return to their devastated villages. Rehabilitating them would have to be the Government's topmost priority. India had set up medical facilities to provide immediate relief and has already committed Rs 100 crore toward rehabilitation. It is now promising another Rs 500 crore in relief measures. The world too is stepping in to help out. But the aid comes with riders: put an end to human rights violations, including muzzling the press and also work towards a more lasting peace. Mahinda Samarasinghe, minister for disaster

THE SQUALID RELIEF CAMPS WHERE TAMIL REFUGEES MAY HAVE TO SPEND OVER TWO YEARS



INTERVIEW | MAHINDA RAJAPAKSE

'India must help rebuild Sri Lanka'

In an exclusive interview, Sri Lankan President Mahinda Rajapakse spoke to INDIA TODAY Managing Editor RAJ CHENGAPPA at his Colombo residence. Excerpts:

Q. What's your feeling after winning the war?

A. It's a relief. After 30 years, we have cleared the terrorists and now we are a unified and whole country.

Q. Did you want Prabhakaran dead or alive?

A. I wish we had captured him alive then we could have sent him to India to face trial for killing former prime minister Rajiv Gandhi. He would then have been India's headache. (laughs)

Q. What was the reason for your success?

A. Unlike others, I united the forces and allowed our commanders to fight the battle. I gave them support. Politicians shouldn't go and fight wars—they should leave it to the generals.

Q. Do you think winning the peace would be more difficult than the war?

A. It would be a tough task but not as difficult as defeating terrorism. I have the will and determination to do it.

Q. What's your immediate priority?

A. We have to rehabilitate and resettle the displaced Tamils, build infrastructure like roads, houses and clear mines from their villages.

Q. What about meeting the political demands of the Tamils?

A. I am committed to implementing the 13th amendment dealing with devolution of power and willing to go even a step further. That step we can discuss and negotiate with political leaders.

Q. Is there a time frame?

A. If you ask the Tamil refugees, what they want immediately—whether water, food and houses or devolution, which will they choose? We have to do things in stages.

Q. What role should India play now?